

REAL WORDS · REAL HEALING

What They Said

*200 things families said that we're still
healing from — and what we needed to
hear instead*

A GUIDED JOURNAL

I didn't write this book.

Thousands of strangers did. One question was asked online — “*What's something a family member said that you'll never fully forgive?*” — and people answered with things they had never said out loud.

I read every answer. I kept the words that stayed. And under each one, I wrote what that person deserved to hear instead.

You don't have to read this in order. Open it anywhere. Write, or don't. Put it down when it gets heavy — that's allowed too.

A gentle note: some pages touch on grief, rejection and hurtful family moments. Stories have been shortened and changed so no one can be identified. If this brings up something big, please reach out to someone you trust or a support line — there's a list at the back.

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01

The Favorite & the Forgotten

*For everyone who grew up watching a
sibling get the softness they were never
given.*

“

My brother died suddenly. At the funeral, my mother turned to me and said it should have been me instead — in front of my children.

— shared by a daughter, 30s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

You were never the spare. Losing him doesn't make you worth less. You are allowed to take up space here — and your grief counts too.

YOUR TURN

Have you ever felt like the “less important” one?
What would you say to the younger you who felt that way?

“

I was crying, and my mom turned to my brother with a smile — “Isn't she so dramatic?” My brother was the one who came over and hugged me.

— shared by a sister, 20s

WHAT YOU NEEDED TO HEAR

Your feelings were never “too much.” And the person who comforted you showed you what love is supposed to look like.

YOUR TURN

Who was the kind one in your story? Write down one thing they did that you still remember.

my brother. he sat with me on the
stairs and didnt say anything, just
stayed. nobody else ever did that.
i didn't know it then but that was
the safest place i had.

*“Their words were a
prediction.
Not a promise.”*

TAKE A BREATH BEFORE YOU TURN THE PAGE

A letter you'll never send

Say the thing you never got to say. No one will read this but you — so say it all.

Dear _____,